

# Lifelong Opportunity Guide 02 — Peer Support Specialist

## **Controlled 2026 English working master**

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Research, organization, editing, and document preparation assisted by ChatGPT, OpenAI

**Controlled status:** This file is the reconstructed English working master for the 2026 revision. It is not yet a publication candidate. It must pass English editorial, factual-source, terminology, accessibility, encoding, structural, link, DOCX, PDF, metadata, and publication QA before release or translation freeze.

## The promise of this guide

This guide does not promise that peer-support work is right for everyone, that training will be free, that a credential will transfer between jurisdictions, or that completing training will lead to a job. It is designed to help readers understand the work, protect their recovery and boundaries, compare education and funding choices, verify local requirements, and make decisions without unnecessary debt or misleading guarantees.

## Why this guide exists

The Lifelong Opportunity Guides are intended to make education and career exploration more accessible to people who may face barriers related to age, disability, income, geography, language, or a nontraditional work history. Peer support can be meaningful work, but it also involves emotional labor, privacy duties, role boundaries, and jurisdiction-specific requirements. A reader should understand those realities before paying for training or accepting an employment obligation.

## Acknowledgment of AI assistance

Alberto (Al) Leiva conceived and directs this project and remains responsible for the guide. ChatGPT by OpenAI was used as an assistive research, organization, editing, and document-preparation tool. AI assistance is not independent human certification, professional translation certification, accreditation, legal review, medical review, accessibility certification, or a substitute for official sources and qualified human judgment.

## Ethical and practical limits

This guide provides general educational and career-navigation information. It is not individualized medical, mental-health, legal, tax, immigration, financial, or licensing advice. Requirements differ by employer, payer, certification body, province, state, territory, country, and work setting. Verify high-impact facts with the current responsible authority before paying, borrowing, relocating, accepting a job, or signing a service or repayment agreement.

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### 1. How to use this guide

Start with the work, not with a school or credential seller.

- Identify the exact job title used in your location.
- Separate legal or payer requirements from common employer preferences and optional advantages.
- Review current local job postings and official sources before relying on national summaries.
- Compare the complete cost of a pathway, including fees, exams, travel, technology, childcare, lost wages, renewals, and unpaid placement time.
- Ask what happens if you cannot complete training or must leave an employer-funded program.
- Pause when a provider pressures you to pay immediately, promises employment, or refuses to provide written costs, refund terms, approval status, or outcome methods.

### 2. What the work is

Peer support workers use lived or living experience, recovery-oriented practice, formal or employer-provided training, and intentional relationship skills to support people pursuing their own recovery and life goals. The role is based on mutuality, hope, respect, choice, and self-direction rather than clinical authority.

SAMHSA describes peer-worker practice as recovery-oriented, person-centered, voluntary, relationship-focused, and trauma-informed. Its core competencies are intended to guide training, job descriptions, supervision, and professional development; they are not a universal national license. Readers in the United States must verify the specific state, Tribal, payer, program, and employer requirements that apply to the job they want.

Common titles include:

- peer support specialist;

- certified peer specialist;
- peer recovery specialist;
- recovery support specialist;
- family peer specialist;
- peer recovery coach; and
- peer support worker.

Common settings include behavioral-health programs, community organizations, hospitals, crisis and stabilization programs, substance-use recovery services, housing and outreach programs, justice-related programs, veterans services, schools, and other community-support settings.

### **3. Duties, tools, and realistic work cycles**

Typical duties may include:

- listening and building a respectful peer relationship;
- supporting self-defined recovery and life goals;
- using self-disclosure intentionally and only when it benefits the person served;
- helping people identify community, housing, benefits, health, recovery, employment, or educational resources;
- supporting navigation without replacing licensed clinical, legal, or benefits professionals;
- documenting required services objectively and minimally;
- recognizing situations that require escalation; and
- participating in supervision, training, quality activities, and personal wellness planning.

A realistic contact may involve reviewing the participant's stated goals, clarifying consent and purpose, listening and exploring options, identifying one practical next step, documenting only required information, escalating immediate safety concerns according to policy, and debriefing with appropriate supervision.

Actual procedures must follow employer policy, applicable law, payer rules, supervision, and emergency protocols.

### **4. Career fit, working conditions, and safety**

Ask yourself:

- Can I listen without taking over another person's decisions?
- Can I use my lived experience selectively rather than making the interaction about me?

- Can I tolerate emotional intensity while maintaining appropriate boundaries?
- Can I follow documentation, privacy, supervision, and escalation requirements even when they feel bureaucratic?
- Can the schedule, transportation, travel, shift work, and caregiving demands fit my household?
- What accommodations or assistive technology would make training and work sustainable?
- Can I enter without unsustainable debt or an unfair employment obligation?

Consider pausing when your own recovery or wellness is not stable enough for the demands of the role, when an employer expects clinical duties beyond your authority, when local credential requirements are unclear, or when training costs and repayment terms have not been verified in writing.

## **5. Ethics, boundaries, privacy, and escalation**

Peer support is not psychotherapy, diagnosis, medication management, legal advice, emergency response, or licensed casework unless the worker separately holds the required qualification and is acting within that authorized role.

Do not create secret, dependent, romantic, financial, exploitative, or coercive relationships with people served. Do not pressure a participant to disclose more than is necessary for the service. Do not promise confidentiality beyond the limits of law, policy, safety procedures, and required reporting.

When someone may be in immediate danger, expresses an imminent intent to harm self or others, reports abuse that triggers a reporting duty, or has an urgent medical problem, follow the employer's emergency and escalation procedures. A peer worker should not improvise a clinical response beyond training and authority.

Use supervision and a personal wellness plan. Protecting your own recovery and capacity is part of sustainable practice, not a failure of commitment.

## **6. Income research, benefits, and outlook**

### **United States — official proxy, not a dedicated peer-support wage series**

The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics does not publish a dedicated Occupational Outlook Handbook wage series solely for peer support specialists. BLS explicitly identifies peer support specialists as one type of community health worker, so Community Health Workers (SOC 21-1094)

can be used as an **official occupational proxy** when clearly labeled as such.

BLS reports a **May 2024 median annual wage of 24.54 per hour)** for community health workers and projects **11% employment growth from 2024 to 2034**. These figures must not be represented as the guaranteed or exact wage/outlook for peer support specialists because the BLS occupation includes workers with different duties and titles.

### United States — current non-government market estimate

As a separate market indicator, ZipRecruiter reported an **average U.S. Peer Support Specialist pay estimate of 19.72 per hour) as of August 7, 2026**, with most reported salaries between about \$35,000 and \$45,000. This is a non-government estimate derived from job-posting and third-party data and should not be treated as an official wage statistic or a guarantee.

### Canada — official occupational grouping

Canada's Job Bank maps "peer support worker" to **Social and community service workers, NOC 42201**. The Job Bank summary page was modified **June 2, 2026**. Its wage table reports a **national median wage of C19.00/C\$36.06**; Job Bank states that these wage values were updated **November 19, 2025**, use a **2023-2024 reference period**, and are sourced from the Statistics Canada Labour Force Survey. Job Bank also notes that prospects vary by province and territory. These data describe the broader NOC 42201 group, so readers should still compare current postings for the exact peer-support title.

### Colombia and the rest of Latin America

Do not invent a national Peer Support Specialist wage where a directly comparable occupational series has not been verified. Job titles, professional boundaries, funding structures, and employment models vary significantly across Latin America. In Colombia, use current employer postings, public employment services, territorial health-system opportunities, community organizations, and official labor information for the actual title being considered. Label any broader occupation or market estimate as a proxy rather than presenting it as a peer-support wage.

### Local wage research checklist

For every country or city, record:

- exact title and duties;
- employer and sector;
- posting date;
- hourly or monthly base pay;

- overtime, shift differential, bonus, or per-service compensation;
- employment status and hours;
- required credential and experience;
- health, retirement, leave, tuition, and other benefits; and
- whether the position requires travel, personal vehicle use, evenings, weekends, or on-call work.

## 7. Education and credentials

### United States

There is no single nationwide peer-support certification that automatically replaces state, Tribal, payer, or employer requirements. Depending on the jurisdiction and role, requirements may include lived experience, recovery-duration criteria, approved training, examination, supervised or work hours, background screening, continuing education, ethics requirements, and recertification.

Before paying:

- identify the official certification or program authority for your state or Tribal jurisdiction;
- confirm whether the credential is required for the exact employer or payer;
- verify training-provider approval directly with that authority;
- confirm all fees, examination rules, supervised-hour requirements, and renewal costs; and
- ask whether the credential transfers if you move.

SAMHSA's core competencies are an authoritative practice framework, not a substitute for state or local credential verification.

### Canada

Peer-support roles and employer requirements vary across Canada. Job Bank places the title within NOC 42201 and indicates that the broader occupation usually involves college/apprenticeship-level preparation or relevant experience. Do not infer from that profile that every peer-support job requires the same diploma, apprenticeship, or credential. Verify the exact employer, provincial, organizational, and program requirements.

### Colombia

Colombia has active national community mental-health policy and 2025 guidance for community mental-health devices, community-based rehabilitation, psychological first aid, and integrated territorial networks. These materials support community participation and mutual-help approaches, but they do **not** establish a U.S.-style nationwide "Certified

Peer Support Specialist" credential. Readers should therefore search by actual Colombian program titles and roles rather than buying a foreign credential on the assumption that it is legally required or automatically recognized.

Potential adjacent learning may include community mental health, psychosocial support, psychological first aid, substance-use prevention, community rehabilitation, communication, safeguarding, and referral skills. Such learning must be labeled as adjacent preparation unless an employer or responsible authority confirms that it satisfies a specific job requirement.

## Latin America

WHO community mental-health and peer-support principles can provide a conceptual framework, but credentials do not automatically transfer across countries. Verify country-specific law, professional-scope rules, employer requirements, language expectations, and recognized training before paying.

## 8. Free and low-cost training, funding, scholarships, and employer support

Use a **free-first** sequence:

1. Learn the work through official public information, public libraries, webinars, open courses, and reputable nonprofit training.
2. Identify the exact credential or employer requirement.
3. Search public workforce funding and employer-paid pathways before paying personally.
4. Compare public colleges, technical institutions, community programs, approved nonprofit providers, and work-based learning.
5. Pay only when the program produces a verified next step such as eligibility, recognized hours, transferable credit, or a documented employer requirement.

## United States funding routes to check

Depending on eligibility and location, examine:

- American Job Center / Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act services;
- state workforce and vocational rehabilitation programs;
- community-college grants and scholarships;
- Pell Grant eligibility for qualifying programs and institutions;
- employer tuition assistance or direct-paid training;
- Medicaid-provider workforce initiatives where applicable;

- SAMHSA-funded recovery/workforce programs when locally available; and
- approved apprenticeships or work-based learning.

Funding availability changes. Verify eligibility, covered costs, tax effects, repayment terms, and whether the training is actually recognized for the target role.

### **Canada funding routes to check**

Check provincial or territorial employment and training programs, public colleges, Indigenous employment and training organizations where applicable, employer-paid learning, community mental-health organizations, scholarships/bursaries, and work-integrated learning. Confirm current eligibility and whether a program is recognized by the intended employer.

### **Colombia funding routes to check**

Check SENA and other public training opportunities, Servicio Público de Empleo listings and training referrals, territorial health and social-program initiatives, cajas de compensación where eligible, employer training, universities' continuing-education offerings, and reputable community organizations. A free or public course should still be evaluated for relevance to the intended role.

## **9. Apprenticeships, work-based learning, and career ladders**

BLS notes that some community health workers participate in apprenticeships or other hands-on programs. That does not mean a peer-support apprenticeship exists in every state or locality.

In the United States, search [Apprenticeship.gov](https://www.apprenticeship.gov) and state apprenticeship agencies using related terms such as peer support, behavioral health, community health worker, recovery support, and human services. Verify that any claimed Registered Apprenticeship is actually registered and identify the sponsor, wages, related instruction, supervision, progression, and credential earned.

In Canada and Latin America, the word "apprenticeship" may refer to systems that do not map directly to peer support. Treat internships, practicums, supervised placements, service-learning, trainee roles, and employer bridge programs according to their actual legal and educational status.

For any work-based program, verify:

- whether participation is paid;
- employee or learner status;



- workers' compensation and insurance;
- supervision qualifications;
- classroom or related instruction;
- documented hours;
- wage progression;
- credential or academic credit;
- portability; and
- what happens if the employer ends the program.

## **10. Employer-supported learning and repayment agreements**

Employers may provide direct-paid training, reimbursement, exam fees, paid study time, scholarships, mentoring, or forgivable education assistance.

Before accepting assistance, obtain written terms covering:

- what is covered and the maximum amount;
- direct payment versus reimbursement;
- grade, exam, attendance, or performance requirements;
- required employment period;
- when the service period begins;
- prorated or full repayment rules;
- treatment of layoff, position elimination, closure, disability, military activation, retirement, death, and employer-directed transfer;
- whether payroll or final-wage deductions are authorized and lawful; and
- who owns transcripts, training records, certificates, and credential documentation.

Do not assume repayment is automatically waived after a layoff or restructuring. Obtain the governing policy or written agreement and seek qualified advice where the consequences are material.

## **11. Accessibility and inclusion**

Accessibility must be checked across the entire pathway, not only at admission.

Potential needs include accessible documents, screen-reader compatibility, captioning, interpreters, quiet testing areas, flexible scheduling, ergonomic equipment, alternative training methods, mobility access, accessible transportation, language support, and disability-related accommodations.

A school, employer, certification body, testing vendor, placement site, apprenticeship sponsor, and public agency may each have a separate accommodation process. Ask early enough to understand documentation requirements and appeal routes, while avoiding unnecessary disclosure beyond what the process requires.

## **12. Privacy, cybersecurity, and ethical AI**

Use only employer-approved systems, devices, accounts, storage, messaging, and AI tools. Never paste protected health information, confidential participant information, case notes, credentials, background-check information, or proprietary employer material into a public AI service unless the employer has explicitly authorized the system and data use.

Use multifactor authentication where required or available. Protect passwords and personal identifiers. Record only the information needed for legitimate work purposes.

AI can help with generic drafting, training simulations using fictional data, or resource organization when permitted, but it must not fabricate services, participant contacts, credentials, clinical conclusions, or documentation. Verify AI-generated factual information before relying on it.

## **13. Build evidence of ability**

Ethical portfolio work can demonstrate judgment without exposing private information. Examples include:

- a fictional community-resource map separating emergency and non-emergency services;
- a boundary and wellness plan;
- a sample objective progress note using fictional information;
- a role-play reflection showing when to listen, when to share lived experience, and when to escalate;
- an accessibility review of publicly available recovery resources; and
- a comparison of two training pathways using documented cost, recognition, and portability criteria.

Explain the problem, your role, the process, the safeguards, the result, and what you learned. Never use real participant information or claim team achievements as individual work.

## **14. Interview preparation**

Prepare concise examples for questions such as:

- How do you decide whether self-disclosure will help the person served?

- How do you preserve mutuality while following documentation and safety requirements?
- What would you do if a participant expresses immediate intent to self-harm?
- How do you respond when a participant rejects an option you believe would help?
- How do you protect your own wellness while working with emotionally intense situations?
- How do you handle information you do not know or a request outside your scope?

Strong answers show the situation, your responsibility, the action you took, the boundary or control you applied, and the result or lesson. Do not invent lived experience, credentials, crisis experience, or outcomes.

## **15. First 30, 60, and 90 days**

### **First 30 days**

Learn role boundaries, supervision, local resources, documentation standards, privacy, safety procedures, accommodations, emergency escalation, attendance, and quality expectations. Clarify what the employer expects you to do independently and what requires approval.

### **Days 31-60**

Perform routine work with appropriate review, strengthen documentation quality, ask for feedback, practice resource navigation, and identify recurring situations that require clarification or escalation.

### **Days 61-90**

Handle a broader routine workload within authority, identify one evidence-based improvement, document professional-development goals, and verify the next training or credential step before paying for it.

## **16. Advancement, portability, and exit planning**

Possible pathways may include senior peer roles, family peer work, recovery coaching, community health work, outreach, program coordination, supervision where permitted, training, quality improvement, or further education in behavioral health and human services.

Do not assume that experience as a peer worker automatically qualifies you for a licensed counseling, psychology, social-work, nursing, or other regulated profession. Those professions have separate education and licensing requirements.

Keep copies of training records, certifications, continuing-education records, evaluations, supervised-hour records where applicable, repayment agreements, accommodation decisions, and employment records. Before relocating, verify credential portability rather than assuming reciprocity.

## 17. Before you enroll, pay, or sign

Confirm in writing:

- exact legal, payer, certification, and employer requirements;
- full pathway cost;
- training-provider approval or institutional accreditation where relevant;
- exam or credential eligibility;
- whether placement is guaranteed, competitive, or the student's responsibility;
- transfer and portability rules;
- refund and complaint procedures;
- employer funding and repayment terms;
- schedule, travel, accessibility, safety, and caregiving impact; and
- what you keep and what you owe if you cannot finish.

## 18. Twelve-week action plan

**Weeks 1-2:** Define strengths, constraints, access needs, recovery/wellness boundaries, and nonnegotiable work conditions.

**Weeks 3-4:** Study the duties, settings, supervision, documentation, safety, privacy, and ethical boundaries.

**Weeks 5-6:** Review current local postings, exact titles, wages, benefits, schedules, and credential requirements.

**Weeks 7-8:** Compare approved training, public/free-first options, work-based pathways, total costs, and portability.

**Weeks 9-10:** Verify funding, scholarships, employer support, tax questions, repayment agreements, accommodations, and exit consequences.

**Weeks 11-12:** Complete fictional or public-data work samples, prepare résumé evidence and interview stories, and decide whether to proceed, pause, or choose a related path.

## 19. Decision and cost worksheets

### Career decision scorecard

Mark each item **Yes**, **Not yet**, or **Major concern**:

- I understand the actual work and have tested my interest.
- I can maintain peer boundaries and protect my own wellness.
- I verified local credential and employer requirements.
- I verified current local wages and benefits.
- The complete pathway is affordable without harmful debt.
- I understand employer repayment terms.
- The entire pathway is accessible to me.
- The schedule, travel, and family impact are workable.
- I understand what the credential will and will not allow me to do.
- I have an advancement and exit plan.

### Cost worksheet

Record an estimate, who may pay, and the verified source/date for:

- tuition and fees;
  - books and training materials;
  - technology and equipment;
  - examinations, certification, renewals, and continuing education;
  - background checks or required documentation;
  - travel, parking, housing, and meals;
  - childcare or eldercare;
  - lost wages or reduced hours; and
  - any repayment obligation.
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## Controlled source ledger — reviewed August 2026

The following sources support the 2026 working master. Publication QA must recheck links and dates before release.

### United States official sources

- SAMHSA — Core Competencies for Peer Workers in Behavioral Health Services:  
<https://www.samhsa.gov/substance-use/recovery/peer-support-workers/core-competencies>  
 Current page last updated March 24, 2026. Used for role principles, competencies, and the explicit distinction between competency guidance and jurisdiction-specific credential requirements.
- SAMHSA — Peer Support Workers for Those in Recovery:  
<https://www.samhsa.gov/substance-use/recovery/peer-support-workers>

Current page last updated March 24, 2026. Used for role context and peer-work functions.

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Community Health Workers: <https://www.bls.gov/ooh/community-and-social-service/community-health-workers.htm>  
Used only as a clearly labeled official proxy because BLS identifies peer support specialists as a type of community health worker. May 2024 median pay: \$51,030; 2024–2034 projected growth: 11%.
- Apprenticeship.gov: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/>  
Locator for registered apprenticeship opportunities. Presence of a related occupation in BLS does not establish that a peer-support apprenticeship exists in every jurisdiction.
- CareerOneStop / American Job Centers: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/AmericanJobCenters/american-job-centers.aspx>  
Locator for public workforce services; funding eligibility must be verified locally.
- Federal Student Aid: <https://studentaid.gov/>  
Federal student-aid information; not all peer-support training programs are aid-eligible.

## United States non-government market source

- ZipRecruiter — Peer Support Specialist Salary: <https://www.ziprecruiter.com/Salaries/Peer-Support-Specialist-Salary>  
Non-government market estimate. As of August 7, 2026: average 19.72/hour). Must remain labeled as a market estimate, not an official wage statistic.

## Canada official sources

- Government of Canada Job Bank — Peer Support Worker summary: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/summary-occupation/24973/ca>  
Title mapped to NOC 42201. Summary page modified June 2, 2026.
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Peer Support Worker wages: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/wages-occupation/24973/ca>  
National low/median/high: C26.00/C\$36.06 per hour. Wage table updated November 19, 2025; reference period 2023–2024; source: Statistics Canada Labour Force Survey. Use as broader NOC 42201 occupational data, not a guarantee for every peer-support position.

## Colombia official sources

- Ministerio de Salud y Protección Social — Salud Mental Comunitaria: <https://www.minsalud.gov.co/salud/publica/salud-mental/Paginas/salud-mental-comunitaria.aspx>  
Current portal includes community-based rehabilitation guidance and 2025 community mental-health-device and psychological-first-aid materials. It supports community and mutual-help pathways but does not establish a U.S.-style national peer-support certification.
- Ministerio de Salud y Protección Social — Política de Salud Mental: <https://www.minsalud.gov.co/salud/publica/salud-mental/Paginas/politica-salud-mental.aspx>
- SENA: <https://www.sena.edu.co/>  
Public training locator. Any course must be verified for current availability and relevance; adjacent mental-health learning is not automatically a Peer Support Specialist credential.
- Servicio Público de Empleo: <https://www.serviciodeempleo.gov.co/>  
Public employment and opportunity locator.

## International / Latin America framework source

- World Health Organization — Peer support mental health services: Promoting person-centred and rights-based approaches: <https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240025783>  
Used as an international conceptual resource for peer support, person-centred services, recovery orientation, and rights-based community mental-health approaches. WHO guidance does not create a portable national occupational credential.
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## Versioning and maintenance controls

- **Working master:** Version 2.0, August 2026.
- This file supersedes neither the v1.0 DOCX nor v1.0 PDF as a publication artifact until QA is complete.